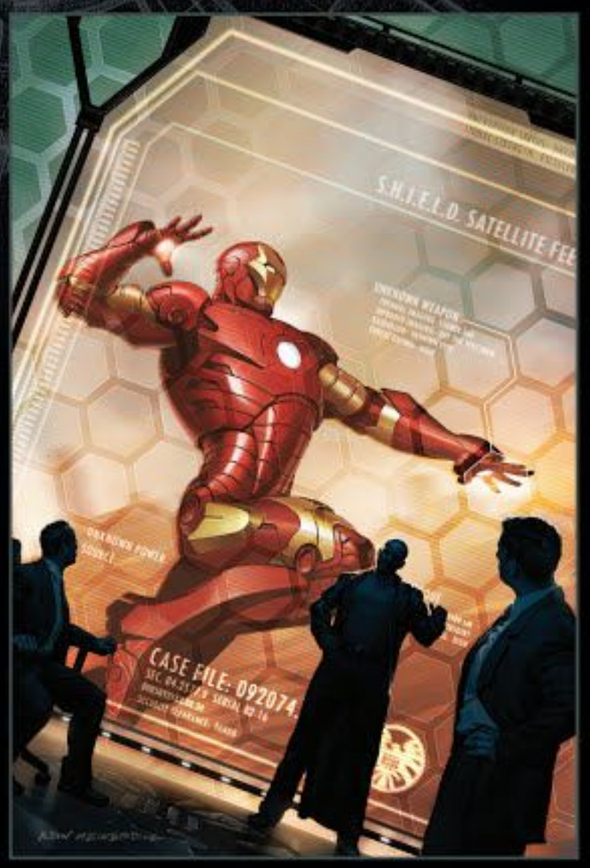
IRON MAN MARK IV ARMOR



Iron Man made his debut in the Tales of Suspense #39, cover-dated April 1963. The story was written by Larry Lieber and drawn by Don Heck. "The thing that made all those formative, early Marvel characters durable over time was that they were a lot more relatable than your average square-jawed super hero had been, up to that point," says Marvel Comics Executive Editor and Vice President Tom Brevoort. Iron Man was different—"He was the sick super hero. His heart was always on the verge of giving out."

That quality was not lost on Stan Lee: "It seems to me, the one thing about Tony Stark that is so great—he is so glamorous, and he is so successful, and he is so virile and such a man, and yet he is very vulnerable. Despite all of that, he has a vulnerability." That vulnerability came to the screen in the first Iron Man, wherein the Repulsor Tech (RT) device in his chest was the only thing keeping him alive.



Over the years in the comics, Iron Man has grappled with alcoholism, fought technology he himself has created, and come to blows against other heroes over ideological issues. All of this would prove to be ripe material for Iron Man 2. "As we were digging through that material," says Co-Producer Jeremy Latcham, "it became apparent that there was a hero there that was kind of unlike all the others. You know, he was a man, he had a point of view, he was an adult, he had real problems."



"Iron Man went through some tough times when the tenor of the times turned against him," Brevoort agrees. When the peace movement gained traction in the late 1960s and early 1970s, "guys like Tony Stark, who were making weapons for the government while there's a war going on that most of the readership of Iron Man was being sent over to fight, these guys were like war profiteers. And Tony had to go through these consciousness-raising back-flips."



That's where we find our hero at the start of Iron Man 2: no longer making weapons and bringing his own brand of privatized peace to the world in the new Mark IV armor. "It's always fun when your hero is the hero from the start," says Producer Kevin Feige. "From frame one of Iron Man 2, he is in the suit. That allows you to just hit the ground running in terms of the story that we're telling."

Art by Ryan Meinerding (top left), Adi Granov (center, right).